

Agentic commerce, where autonomous AI agents independently select and purchase products on behalf of consumers, is forcing retailers to rethink their role. As AI takes over more of the buying process, physical stores are evolving from a sales channel into a destination for advice, service, experience, and omnichannel support

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how consumers shop

Agentic commerce fundamentally changes the buying process

Retail is entering a new phase of digital disruption. E-commerce has already transformed *where* consumers shop; agentic commerce is set to change *how* they shop. Autonomous artificial intelligence agents can search, compare and purchase products on behalf of consumers, shifting shopping from an active task to an increasingly automated background process.

Agentic commerce goes beyond AI assistants and comparison websites

Key differences between agentic commerce, AI assistants (such as ChatGPT and Gemini) and comparison websites

	Agentic commerce	AI assistants	Comparison websites
Role in customer journey	Actively manages parts of the customer journey	Provides information and recommendations	Helps consumers compare products and prices
Degree of autonomy	High: can execute tasks independently	Low to medium: provides recommendations	None
Decision-making role	Makes decisions	Decisions remain with	Decisions remain with

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Adoption is likely to be slower for luxury, trend-sensitive and experience-driven products. In these categories, inspiration, emotion, and personal preference remain central to the purchasing decision, making consumers less inclined to relinquish control. AI agents can assist by pre-selecting products that match predefined preferences, but final purchasing decisions are likely to remain firmly in the hands of the consumer.

Consumer electronics and personal care lead the adoption of agentic commerce

Within non-food retail, agentic commerce appears particularly well suited to consumer electronics and personal care. Both sectors are characterised by a high degree of product standardisation and a large share of repeat purchases, making them ideal candidates for AI-driven purchasing.

In consumer electronics, purchasing decisions are often based on objective and easily comparable criteria, including price, technical specifications, and availability. This makes products such as

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Product categories most and least suited to agentic commerce

Segment	Suitable for agentic commerce	Products most suited	Products least suited
Consumer electronics	High	Standardised products with clearly measurable specifications.	Hobby-related products and more complex products that require expert advice
Personal care	Medium to high	Routine and repeat purchases	New product launches, fragrances and highly personal products
Fashion	Medium	Basic apparel (t-shirts and socks)	Trend-driven and luxury fashion items
Home furnishings	Medium	Functional furniture, replacement purchases, and products with clearly measurable features.	Trend-driven products, customised products, and decorative items

Source: ING Research

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Agentic commerce creates the greatest opportunities for large global marketplaces and technology companies. These players combine vast product assortments with the scale, data and infrastructure needed to deploy AI agents effectively. Their integrated ecosystems, including payment solutions, logistics networks, and data platforms, enable them to integrate AI agents into their business operations faster and more effectively.

Chinese platforms such as Alibaba and JD.com currently lead the way, with AI agents already deeply integrated into their respective platform networks. These agents can not only provide product

recommendations but also complete purchases autonomously. Meanwhile, US technology companies including Amazon, Google, Meta, OpenAI and Anthropic are investing heavily in the development and rollout of AI agents, intensifying the global race for leadership in this emerging market.

European players are structurally lagging behind their American and Chinese competitors. Stricter regulation and less integrated platform networks limit their ability to bundle scale, data and services. While Zalando is among Europe's frontrunners in AI-powered retail, its applications are currently focused on product discovery, comparison, and selection. Fully autonomous

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How will the role of the physical store evolve in an AI-driven retail landscape?



From transaction to experiences

Less focus on selling, greater emphasis on advice, and product experience (seeing, touching, and testing).



A key part of the omnichannel model

Stores become integral links in the customer journey through click & collect, returns, and fast delivery.



Building brand value and trust

Physical stores increasingly serve as showrooms that strengthen brand experience, trust and customer loyalty.



Service and expertise become key differentiators

Personal advice and specialist knowledge help physical stores stand out from online channels.



More targeted store traffic

Formerly, more relevant customers visit with stores

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Retailers that successfully integrate their physical and digital channels, define clear roles for their stores, and deploy technology strategically can strengthen their position within the customer journey. In a future shaped by AI-driven commerce, their role will increasingly centre on adding value where automation cannot.

Retail

Consumption

AI

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